The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Their extreme gloom has dissipated, but Americans are still far from enthused by the economy. The preliminary reading of the University of Michigan's consumer sentiment index—a closely watched indicator—edged down to 76.5 in March, the second consecutive mild decline. At its current level, it is consistent with weak economic growth. Still, it is up strongly from early 2023, when the sentiment score was seen as a warning sign for a possible recession.

For the Biden administration, the public mood has been a source of frustration. America's recent economic growth has been impressive, but many people still seem more focused on high inflation than on the strong labour market. Analysts argue that political partisanship may be clouding survey responses and that it will take a while longer for people to digest the surge in prices that primarily hit in 2022. In this context a modest improvement in sentiment may be the best Joe Biden can hope for.

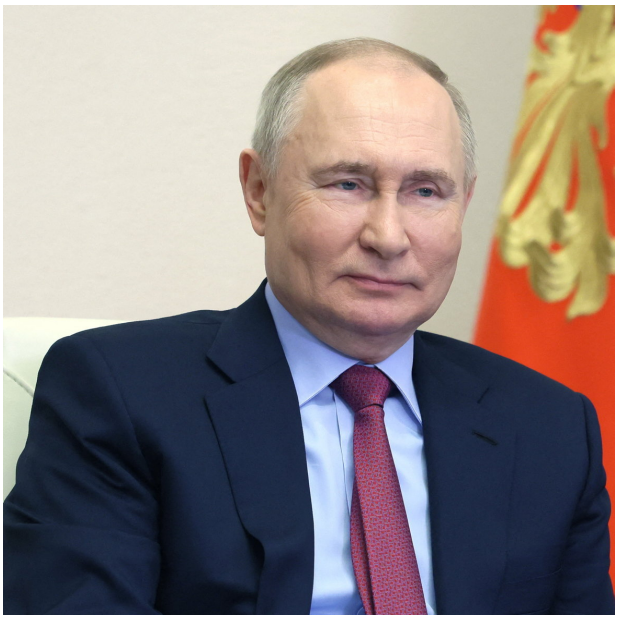


Photo: Getty Images

Russia’s sham election

On Friday voting began in Russia’s presidential election. The result is not in doubt: Vladimir Putin will win another six-year term. He controls the media and has closed civil-society groups. (Golos, Russia’s only independent election-monitoring organisation, has been designated a “foreign agent”.) Opposition figures have been silenced, imprisoned and killed. Boris Nadezhdin, an anti-war politician, collected enough signatures to gain a place on the ballot, but was banned from standing. On February 16th Alexei Navalny, Russia’s most prominent opposition leader, died in the Siberian penal colony where he was incarcerated on spurious charges.

In that context, holding the vote may seem pointless. But the exercise is important to Mr Putin. His rule relies on carefully maintaining the appearance of popular support. The election is a ritualistic expression of that approval. It will embolden the president to continue his war in Ukraine and his campaign of repression at home.

Photo: EPA

The collapse of India’s fintech star

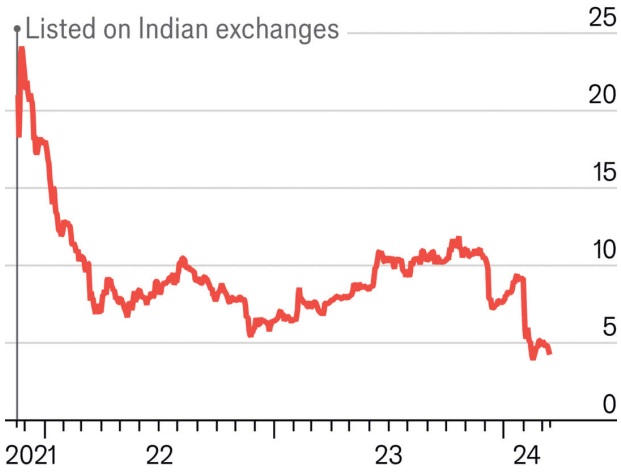
For years, Paytm was the trailblazer in India's booming fintech scene. The startup pioneered digital payments in the country, accumulating 100m active users and attracting billions in venture capital. In 2021 it went public at a valuation of $20bn, in what was then India's biggest-ever IPO. These days, though, the company is struggling.

Paytm's share price has slumped amid concerns over its profitability. And in trying to attract more users it has cut corners, angering regulators. On Thursday the firm is shutting its banking arm on the orders of India's central bank because of "persistent non-compliances", such as opening accounts without proper identification.

The crackdown will have far-reaching implications. Users with Paytm bank accounts, including many small businesses, will have to withdraw their money. Many of the other 7,000 fintech startups in India may have to tone down their similarly aggressive approaches to recruiting customers. Paytm's success story has become a cautionary tale.

Rise and fall

Paytm, share price, $



Source: LSEG Workspace

Photo: Getty Images

Macron, Scholz and Tusk meet

When Emmanuel Macron, France's president, visits Berlin on Friday he will attempt to mend fences with Olaf Scholz, the German chancellor. The pair differ in temperament and political instinct—and in recent weeks they have also disagreed over the war in Ukraine.

Taking the Germans by surprise, at the end of February Mr Macron publicly mused that Western countries might send ground troops to Ukraine. Mr Scholz immediately rejected the idea. German officials were especially irritated by such hawkish talk as France has provided only €635m ($693m) in military aid to Ukraine, while Germany has delivered or promised €17.7bn, calculates the Kiel Institute for the World Economy (figures the French government contests.). Messrs Macron and Scholz will later be joined by Donald Tusk, the Polish prime minister, for a meeting of the Weimar Triangle, a geopolitical forum born in 1991 after the end of the cold war. Poland and Germany are particularly keen to resuscitate it.

Photo: © Amazon Prime

Frida Kahlo, in her own words

Frida Kahlo is one of Mexico's greatest cultural exports. She is Latin America's most expensive artist, and the Blue House, her home in Coyoacán, is one of the most visited museums in Mexico City. Yet Kahlo is also revered as a feminist icon in a way oddly detached from her life and work. Her ubiquitous likeness—replete with her characteristic unibrow—adorns all manner of trinkets, including plates and socks.

"Frida", a documentary released on Prime Video this week, uses Kahlo's diaries and letters to tell her story in her own words. It covers the bus crash that nearly killed her at the age of 18, her tempestuous marriage to Diego Rivera, a fellow painter, and her affairs (among them one with Leon Trotsky). Throughout, her paintings and drawings are brought to life with careful animation. It is a vivid portrait of a singular artist, who strove to portray the world "through no one else's eyes" but her own.

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each day this week. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and, as important, tell us the connecting theme. Email your responses (and include mention of your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick randomly from those with the right answers and crown three winners on Saturday.

Friday: Which English county contains the cities of Portsmouth and Southampton?

Thursday: The white rose was the symbol of which English royal house?

Dissents speak to a future age.

Ruth Bader Ginsburg